

53 CASES · 2004 TO 2025

The Evidence Trap

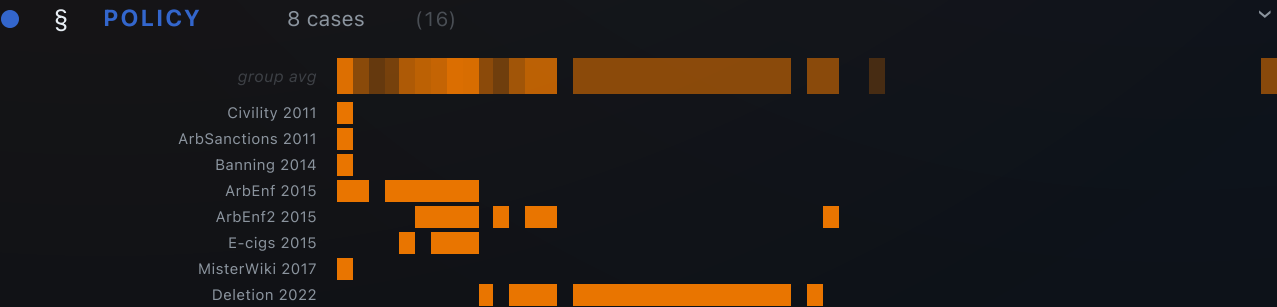
Why fact-based conflicts never settle

THE PATTERN

In political cases, the committee gathers evidence, rules, and moves on. The evidence phase clears within the first third of the timeline. In science and geopolitics, the evidence phase never fully releases. The argument loops back, demands more proof, and the case starves for a decision that facts alone cannot deliver.

WHAT WIKIPEDIA'S LAST RESORT REVEALS

The Arbitration Committee is Wikipedia's court of **last resort**. Cases only reach it after every lower forum has failed. When those cases cluster around disputed **facts** rather than disputed **conduct**, they stay open longer because the committee cannot rule on what reality is. It can only manage behavior around the disagreement. The evidence trap is not a process failure. It is a signal that some conflicts are structurally beyond arbitration's reach.



WHY THESE CASES CAME BACK

Arbitration Enforcement (2011, 2015, 2015): Three cases over four years as the community kept finding its enforcement procedures insufficient. Each case tightened the rules, but the new rules created new ambiguities that required their own arbitration. The second and third cases in 2015 ran nearly simultaneously, reflecting how quickly the policy was being stress-tested.

Disputes about Wikipedia's own enforcement rules and banning procedures — cases where the community turned its dispute-resolution apparatus on itself to debate how

arbitration should work.



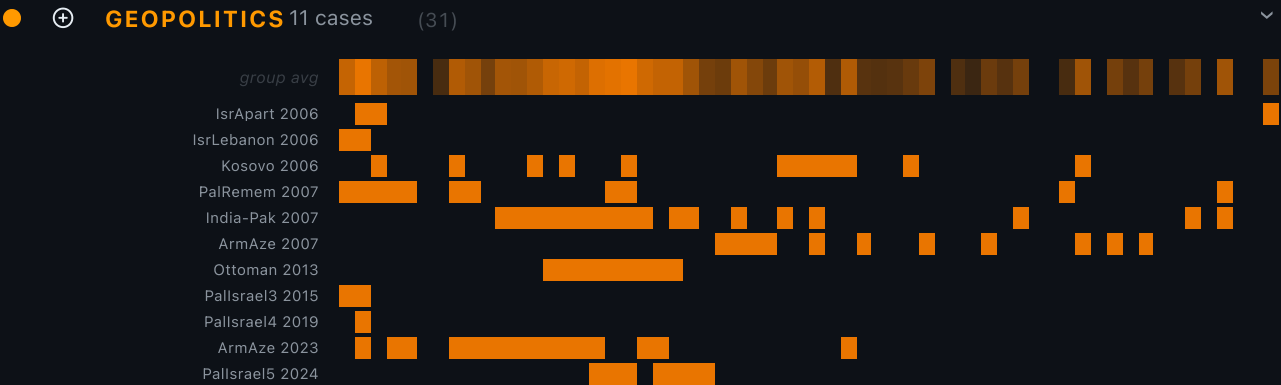
WHY THESE CASES CAME BACK

American Politics (2014 + 2015): The 2015 case reopened within months because the prior sanctions were insufficient to stop battleground editing ahead of U.S. elections. The committee had to tighten restrictions twice in a single election cycle.

Disputes over political figures, elections, and partisan articles — editor allegiances here often mirror real-world party divides more than Wikipedia sourcing standards.



Cases involving identity, demographics, and social policy — contested cultural definitions make neutral framing structurally difficult, and the battlegrounds shift as terminology evolves.



WHY THESE CASES CAME BACK

Palestine–Israel (2015, 2019, 2024): Three cases across nine years. Each resolved the immediate editor conduct but could not settle the underlying historical narrative. New rounds of real-world conflict — 2014 Gaza war, 2021 escalation, October 2023 —

brought fresh waves of editors with the same framing disputes, requiring the committee to intervene again each time.

Armenia–Azerbaijan (2007, 2023): Sixteen years separated the two cases. The 2023 case followed the 2020 and 2023 Nagorno-Karabakh wars and introduced an entirely new cohort of nationalist editors, many with no prior Wikipedia history, relitigating the same territorial framing disputes as the 2007 case.

Territorial and ethnic disputes — especially in the Middle East and the former Soviet Union — where competing national narratives about history are irreconcilable and real-world events keep reopening old wounds.



WHY THESE CASES CAME BACK

Ebionites (2007 + 2013): A small, persistent group of editors with fringe theological views returned six years after the first case with the same sourcing disputes largely intact. The original remedies expired without resolving the underlying belief conflict.

Conflicts over doctrine, sacred figures, and religious institutions — editors frequently treat their faith tradition as an authority that Wikipedia's neutrality policy cannot override.



WHY THESE CASES CAME BACK

Climate Change (2005, 2005, 2010): Three separate arbitration cases in five years tracked successive waves of skeptic editors. The first two cases in 2005 named different editors for the same dispute; the 2010 case reopened in the wake of the Climategate controversy, which briefly gave fringe editors new ammunition.

Theresa Knott / Mr-Natural-Health (both 2004): Two cases filed the same year about the same underlying dispute — one named the editor, one named the article topic. The committee split the proceedings to handle conduct and content separately, which is why both appear as distinct cases.

Edit wars over empirically contested claims — climate change, alternative medicine, pseudoscience — where minority viewpoints seek equal footing with scientific

consensus on the grounds of editorial fairness.

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